

LAWS AND CRIMES IN THE METAVERSE

WE DON'T PLAY BY YOUR RULES HERE

Satvik Pandey | feedback@digit.in

Some people enjoy the idea of being able to smash into parked cars on an insanely fast motorcycle, because you're running from the cops after robbing a bank. Normally when a motorcycle smashes into a car there's only one loser, but in your world, you're indestructible! This is the experience that led to the popularity of the GTA video games (GTA V in particular). So many of us built an empire there, and lived different lives inside the game. None of us want to be bank robbers in the real world, we just liked the escapism of being the bad guy for once. And then you lose your login credentials to some hacker kid, and it's a nightmare, because even though it's a world of make believe, it's one we worked hard at!

What's this got to do with the metaverse? Just like with games, the metaverse too isn't "real", but it will take real effort and time to build and nurture a presence in it. It's not just 1's and 0's being processed by a GPU and shown to you, it's something we will have an emotional attachment to, and will have invested time and real money into, whenever it gets here. And we are going to need ways to protect those assets we have or create! We will need laws!

PRIVACY

A simple browser cookie reveals so much about us that we're uncomfortable about it. As it is technology is spooky, with ads suddenly

appearing for things we swear we were just talking about with friends or family members. The way tech has invaded our lives, and the lack of privacy is already unsettling, imagine what happens when that entire life is lived digitally?

Is it the end of our privacy when we will be using a system that allows us to "live" online? Imagine, you're walking through a virtual world, and now everything you choose to focus on, what you look at, zoom into, stop in front of, interact with, all of it is data about your behaviours. If you think it's spooky how well algorithms know you now, prepare to be terrified soon!



What data will meta be after?

With one or two of the big tech companies essentially owning the metaverse, they're also going to be the ones who own all of the data about you (not too different from today, thus far), but the difference between what's real and what's metaverse might start to blur. This is something we will explore in more detail in the next story, but in terms of privacy, that's a bad, bad thing.

Our only hope is legal recourse, and world governments hopefully

siding with us instead of corporations (unlikely), to have strict opt-in policies and personal control over our own data and its use. Let's hope it doesn't come too late.

CRIME

As life in the metaverse becomes more and more complex, there will be more and more opportunities for crime to occur. And we're not talking about the crimes of privacy breaches that companies commit by selling our data, that was the last section. In this section we're talking more about companies being hacked and our data being leaked to the highest bidder. More complex systems end up with more security holes to block.

We need to prepare for user-on-user crimes as well, including cyber trespassing, deception, violence, obscenity, and harassment. People do all of these things already on the internet, there's no reason they will not continue to do so in the metaverse. So expect to be targeted and harassed for your race, gender, beliefs, support of a sports team, your choice of Android or Apple, political stands, and just about any thought or belief you choose to express. Already there are reports of sexual assaults occurring in the early days of the metaverse, and debates have already started. Can your avatar being molested count as actual molestation? Is it an overreaction of sorts, or should we truly embrace the metaverse as an extension of our lives, and consider things done in the metaverse as a crime, if those would be a crime in the real world.

Imagine if a group of men were to surround a woman on the street of your town, and crowd around her, not allowing her to move away, and start using filthy language to intimidate and scare her, making threats of rape and molestation. Surely that counts as sexual assault, right? Now if the same were done to a female character in the metaverse, is that a crime? Shouldn't it be? Who decides? Do we have police patrols in the metaverse now, to stop such disgusting behaviour? Do we have metaverse jails to punish criminals for illegal behav-